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ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

ESA astronaut Luca Parmitano named pilot for Artemis III LEO docking mission



Credit: NASA

On 9 June 2026, **NASA announced the crew for its Artemis III mission, planned for late 2027, naming ESA astronaut Luca Parmitano of Italy as pilot** — the first ESA astronaut ever assigned to an Artemis mission. Parmitano will fly alongside NASA commander Randy Bresnik and mission specialists Frank Rubio and Andre Douglas. The mission will remain in LEO, where Orion will demonstrate rendezvous and docking capabilities with commercial lunar landers developed by SpaceX and Blue Origin, validating the integrated hardware and operations required for Artemis IV — the first planned crewed lunar landing, targeted for 2028. Parmitano has spent 366 days in space across two ISS missions and was the first Italian to command the station.

Upgraded Ariane 64 deploys 36 Amazon LEO satellites on VA269



Credit: Arianespace

On 17 June 2026, Arianespace successfully launched 36 Amazon LEO satellites from the Guiana Space Centre on mission VA269, the third Ariane 6 flight dedicated to the constellation and the first to fly with the new P160C solid-propellant boosters. The new configuration increases Ariane 64's performance by 10% in LEO and raises its payload capacity to approximately 22 tonnes. The 36-satellite stack is the heaviest payload ever launched by an Ariane rocket, surpassing by four satellites the batches deployed on VA267 and VA268. The mission, the eighth Ariane 6 flight overall and the third in the four-booster configuration, brings the total number of Amazon LEO satellites placed into orbit by Arianespace to 100, across three launches in under five months. VA269 forms part of an 18-launch series contracted between Arianespace and Amazon for the full constellation deployment.

France, UK and Czech Republic sign astronaut missions to ISS and Haven-1 with Vast



Credit: Vast

On 1 June 2026, **France and Vast signed a two-mission agreement brokered with CNES, covering a private astronaut mission to the ISS and a crewed test flight of Haven-1**. ESA astronaut Thomas Pesquet has been designated to serve as commander of the ISS mission, subject to approval from the ISS Multilateral Crew Operations Panel, while ESA reserve astronaut Arnaud Prost is set to fly as flight test engineer on the Haven-1 inaugural crewed mission. Both flights are planned for 2027 aboard a SpaceX Dragon. The following day, **the UK Space Agency also signed an MoU with Vast to explore the opportunity for ESA reserve astronaut John McFall** — the first person with a physical disability to be medically cleared for a long-duration spaceflight — to fly to Haven-1 in 2027, with UKSA and Vast tasked with jointly securing sponsorships to fund the mission. On 8 June, **ESA signed a further agreement on behalf of the Czech Republic with Vast for a private astronaut mission to the ISS in 2027**, with ESA reserve astronaut Aleš Svoboda — who would become the first Czech astronaut to visit the ISS — named as mission pilot, flying alongside Pesquet. Vast also confirmed it will establish its European headquarters in Paris.

Portugal expands SAR constellation and CEiiA signs Iberian constellation partnership

On 17 June 2026, **CTI Aeroespacial — a joint venture between the Portuguese Air Force and engineering centre CEiiA — signed a contract with ICEYE for two additional satellite systems**, bringing the Portuguese Air Force's total ICEYE-built constellation to four satellites. Portugal's first sovereign SAR satellite was launched in March 2026 and is already in operational use. With four satellites, the Portuguese Air Force gains sufficient revisit rates to operate a high-tempo constellation covering the Atlantic maritime domain and Portugal's Exclusive Economic Zone, with dual-use applications extending to environmental monitoring and disaster response. The acquisition positions Portugal among a group of seven European nations operating sovereign ICEYE-built constellations. **CEiiA also signed a Letter of Intent with Telespazio Ibérica establishing a framework for strategic cooperation aimed at federating sovereign satellite constellations across the Iberian Peninsula and, over time, other European countries including Italy**. Near-term collaboration focuses on integrating CEiiA ground segment components into Telespazio Ibérica's Canary Islands constellation and jointly bidding for the European Commission's future Earth Observation Service. The stated longer-term ambition is to contribute to an interoperable network of nationally operated constellations in support of Europe's broader space sovereignty objectives.

ESA and Commission expand Flight Ticket Initiative to new launch providers

ESA and the European Commission launched a two-part call for proposals on 25 June 2026, opening the European Flight Ticket Initiative to additional European launch service providers. The Initiative, jointly funded through the EU's Horizon Europe programme and ESA's Boost! programme, co-funds launch services for In-Orbit Demonstration and Validation (IOD/IOV) missions, allowing European companies to test new space technologies in orbit while creating launch opportunities for domestic providers. The first part of the call invites new entrants to apply for framework contracts, expanding the pool beyond the four providers — Avio, Isar Aerospace, PLD Space, and Rocket Factory Augsburg — selected in the initial 2024 round. The second part assigns launch opportunities for the fifth batch of IOD/IOV missions, with six previously shortlisted missions now ready for launch and open to bids from both existing and newly selected providers. Proposals are due by 17 July 2026.



Credit: ESA

French DGA places first €138M OneWeb capacity order under Centaure programme

France's defence procurement agency DGA signed a contract worth €138M over four years for Eutelsat OneWeb LEO satellite capacity on 15 June 2026 at the Eurosatory armaments exhibition in Paris, signed by DGA chief Patrick Pailloux and Eutelsat CEO Jean-François Fallacher in the presence of French Defence Minister Catherine Vautrin. The contract, named Centaure, has a maximum value of €350M over eight years and represents the first tranche under the ten-year, €1B commitment made in June 2025 through the broader NEXUS framework agreement. The capacity will be rolled out across French Armed Forces platforms — vehicles, surface vessels, and aircraft — with DGA aiming to progressively raise the security and functionality of the OneWeb system to expand military applications, working alongside its Syracuse 4 GEO satellites as part of a hybridised satellite communications strategy. The French government, Eutelsat's largest shareholder, has positioned OneWeb as a training ground for the future IRIS2 multi-orbit constellation, in which Eutelsat holds prime responsibility for the LEO shell.

Leonardo selected to develop SCOPE servicer under EU's ISOS programme



Credit: European Commission

The European Commission selected Leonardo to develop SCOPE, one of two servicer spacecraft under the In-Space Operations and Services (ISOS) programme. The programme, launched under Horizon Europe in collaboration with ESA, aims to build a European orbital infrastructure for in-space operations including inspection, repositioning, robotic manipulation, refuelling, in-orbit assembly and manufacturing, and debris removal, built around an ecosystem of specialised "servicer" satellites and an orbital "HOST" robotic platform serving as a storage, testbed, and logistics hub. SCOPE will draw on the space systems engineering, robotics, and ground segment expertise of Leonardo and its joint ventures Thales Alenia Space and Telespazio, in partnership with Airbus, Indra, and GMV, combining two robotic arms, AI-based autonomy, and standardised docking and refuelling interfaces. **The selection was announced alongside the wider ISOS Joint Declaration, signed by Greece, Italy, the Netherlands, Sweden, and Norway — joining Germany, France, Luxembourg, Portugal, and Spain, which signed in 2025 — together with the European Commission and ESA**. The declaration also marked the start of six Horizon Europe projects supporting the ISOS pilot mission, targeted for 2030, including Thales Alenia Space's EROSS SC servicer project — the second of the two servicer spacecraft — and a HOST platform consortium led by The Exploration Company, in which Leonardo will define the robotic systems supporting docking and berthing operations.

China launches ten orbital missions across seven rocket types, and a spaceplane



Credit: China Aerospace Science and Technology Corporation

China's space launch month opened on 1 June with the unannounced maiden flight of the Long March 12B from Jiuquan, China's most capable single-core rocket, which carried operational Qianfan broadband satellites directly on its debut. **Two further Qianfan batches of 18 satellites each followed on 4 and 5 June aboard a Long March 6A and a Long March 8**, respectively, pushing the constellation's total to 200 satellites in orbit. **On 9 June**, **LandSpace's Zhuque-2E lifted off carrying two D2D test satellites**, one for Qianfan operator SpaceSail and one for China Mobile, though the upper stage broke up in orbit the same day. Later in the month, **Long March 5 launched the classified TJS-25 communications technology satellite into GEO transfer orbit**, marking the 650th Long March launch overall, while a C**AS Space Kinetica-1 rocket delivered eight Jilin-1 Gaofen satellites for commercial EO operator Changguang Satellite**. Successively, **Long March 3B carried the classified Shijian-31 satellite on 16 June, followed the next day by a Long March 12 delivering the 22nd Guowang broadband batch and a the launch of Kuaizhou-11 solid rocket**. **The Long March 7A then launched TJS-26A into GEO transfer orbit on 23 June**, marking the 44th Chinese orbital launch of the year. Finally, **commercial space-tracking firm LeoLabs reported on 22 June that China's secretive Shenlong reusable spaceplane** — on its fourth orbital mission since February — had released an unidentified object into orbit, consistent with sub-satellite deployment patterns observed on previous missions.

IN OTHER NEWS

ESA Council appoints two new directors

ESA's Council approved the appointment of Christine Klein as Director of Controlling, Finance and Operational Procurement, effective 1 July 2026, and Jean-Luc Trullemans as Director of Strategy, Legal and External Affairs, effective 1 January 2027.

NASA awards nearly $600M for Moon Base science missions

NASA selected Astrobotic ($297.9M for two deliveries), Firefly Aerospace ($144.2M), and Intuitive Machines ($148.3M) under its Commercial Lunar Payload Services initiative to land four science and technology payloads on the Moon in late 2028, as part of the agency's Moon Base Programme.

JAXA's H3 returns to flight in lowest-cost variant

JAXA's H3 rocket returned to flight on 12 June 2026 from Tanegashima Space Centre with the debut of the H3-30 configuration. Six secondary payloads were successfully deployed, and the second stage was deorbited over the Indian Ocean.

US Space Force awards Boeing $2B contract for MUOS satellite

The US Space Force awarded Boeing a contract valued at up to $2B on 25 June 2026 for the Mobile User Objective System Service Life Extension (MUOS SLE) programme, covering the development and delivery of two narrowband UHF communications satellites built on Boeing's 702MP platform, with first delivery scheduled for 2031.

Botswana signs Artemis Accords as sixth African signatory

Botswana signed the Artemis Accords on 25 June 2026, becoming the 68th signatory and the sixth African nation to join the framework.

IRIS2 adds 66 early-delivery LEO satellites

Europe's IRIS2 programme is adding 66 smaller LEO satellites to enable initial secured government services from 2030, ahead of the full 264-satellite constellation now targeted for 2032.

Airbus partners with four German companies for ISR capability



Credit: Airbus

Airbus Defence and Space has signed an MoU with Rohde & Schwarz, constellr, Orbint and High Performance Space Structure Systems (HPS) during the Berlin Air Show on 10 June 2026. The partnership aims to develop an end-to-end satellite-based EO and Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) system. The joint solution addresses the full EO chain, including multi-sensor tasking, collection, processing, exploitation and dissemination. The system will combine RF-sensors, electro-optical and infrared (EO/IR), SAR technologies, and signal-related geospatial intelligence. Airbus will act as prime contractor and system integrator and will be responsible for the overall mission.

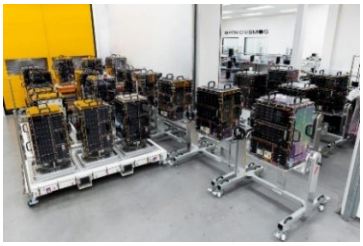
Look Up selects Skynopy for automated satellite collision avoidance service

On 17 June 2026 French-based company Look Up selected also French firm Skynopy to provide the ground-segment interface for its Acceleration Towards LEO Automatic Space Safety (ATLAS²) programme. The programme, co-funded by the European Union for up to 70% of the €3.4M, aims to enable satellites to respond automatically to collision threats detected by Look Up's terrestrial radar network. Under a two-phase contract, Skynopy will design and demonstrate the integration of its virtualised ground station network with the ATLAS² platform. This will enable real-time satellite command-and-control in response to detected threats.

Shield Space partners with ClearSpace on satellite defence capabilities

Luxembourg-headquartered ClearSpace and British startup Shield Space signed an MoU on 23 June 2026 to develop sovereign space defence capabilities for the United Kingdom and allied nations. The agreement establishes a framework for integrating Shield Space's autonomous satellite operations software with ClearSpace's in-orbit inspection, life-extension, debris removal and in-orbit servicing capabilities. The two companies said their agreement also provides the foundation for a broader industrial consortium focused on sovereign space defence, with further details expected in the coming months.

Open Cosmos seeks ITU deadline extension for broadband constellation



Credit: Open Cosmos

British company Open Cosmos has requested a one-year extension from the ITU to its 10 June deadline to deploy half of its planned sovereign broadband constellation for Europe. The company cited the January 2026 failure of India's PSLV rocket as a force majeure event. Liechtenstein, which holds the Ka-band spectrum filings used by the network, submitted the extension request on Open Cosmos's behalf, covering 144 satellites. Under ITU rules, the number of satellites deployed by the halfway milestone determines the maximum constellation size eligible to retain priority spectrum rights, with full deployment due by June 2028.

The spectrum filings were previously held by Germany-based Rivada Space Networks, but Liechtenstein rescinded the licences in 2024 following a dispute over a performance bond. The filings were reassigned to Open Cosmos earlier this year, which activated them by launching two prototype satellites with Rocket Lab in January 2026.

Eutelsat expands OneWeb partnerships for regional and maritime connectivity

Eutelsat has concluded several agreements in June 2026 to extend its OneWeb LEO connectivity services across regional broadband and maritime markets. Early in the month, **Eutelsat and Airtel Madagascar have deepened their satellite broadband partnership** to deploy LEO broadband services to underserved communities and integrate satellite connectivity with existing fibre and 4G infrastructure.

Eutelsat also signed a new agreement with Cyprus-based Totoheo Global to provide Eutelsat's LEO services to maritime customers worldwide, as well as to enterprise and government clients across Greece and Cyprus**, while Finnish telecommunications operator Voimatel agreed to integrate Eutelsat's OneWeb LEO services into its network solutions to strengthen connectivity across Finland**, particularly in Arctic regions where terrestrial networks are limited

Finally, on 22 June 2026, **Eutelsat and AST Networks concluded a multi-year,** multi-million-dollar deal to expand OneWeb LEO services within AST Networks' hybrid connectivity solutions for maritime customers worldwide.

ICEYE expands disaster monitoring partnerships and appoints new US executives

During the month, ICEYE concluded five new partnerships through its SAR satellite constellation. **On 4 June, ICEYE and the Florida Flood Hub for Applied Research and Innovation partnered to strengthen flood preparedness across Florida**. Under the agreement, state agencies and water management districts will have access to ICEYE's flood monitoring and early warning tools. **On 15 June, the company and US insurer Liberty launched a building-level parametric wildfire insurance solution. On 17 June, ICEYE and Indian space company Dhruva Space signed a MoU** covering satellite manufacturing, EO, disaster management, and ground segment infrastructure. The next day, **ICEYE also signed a contract with the Norwegian Water Resources and Energy Directorate (NVE**) to provide a nationwide SAR-based flood monitoring service across mainland Norway and Svalbard. Finally, **on 29 June, the Spanish-based company Iberdrola selected ICEYE for a project to strengthen its electricity grid against extreme weather events.** The initiative will be piloted in Spain before extending to wind and hurricane damage assessment for Iberdrola's assets in the US and Australia. ICEYE has also appointed **Eric Jensen as global Chief Operating Officer** and **Ann Stevens as Chief Executive Officer of ICEYE US,** both effective 2 June 2026.

Astrobotic unveils Griffin-1 lunar lander for NASA's Moon Base mission



Credit: Astrobotic

Astrobotic has unveiled its Griffin-1 lunar lander at its Pittsburgh headquarters on 15 June 2026, ahead of the spacecraft's planned fourth-quarter 2026 launch aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket. Developed under NASA's Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) programme, Griffin-1 will serve as the lander for NASA's Moon Base II mission. The lander will carry ten payloads from six nations, including Astrolab's FLIP rover, expected to become the heaviest commercial payload delivered to the lunar surface to date. The spacecraft will next undergo environmental testing at NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory in California before final integration and shipment to Florida for launch.

Rocket Lab sets TacRS launch record and launches 10th Synspective satellite



Credit: Rocket Lab

Rocket Lab has successfully launched the Victus Haze spacecraft aboard its Electron rocket from Mahia, New Zealand, on 19 June 2026. The mission lifted off 16 hours and 42 minutes after Rocket Lab received its launch order from the US Space Force, beating the previous Tactically Responsive Space (TacRS) turnaround record by more than 10 hours. This was the first time a single prime contractor delivered an all-in-one mission package for a TacRS mission. Following commissioning, the spacecraft will conduct RPO in LEO alongside a spacecraft operated by Colorado-based startup True Anomaly, to stimulate a rapid threat response to a non-compliant satellite. Later in the month, **on 27 June, Rocket Lab also successfully launched the 10th StriX radar-imaging satellite for Japanese EO company Synspective** aboard its Electron rocket from its Launch Complex 1 site in New Zealand**.** The "Ten Owl of Ten" mission deployed the SAR satellite into a 552-kilometre orbit, with Synspective having further 17 missions booked with Rocket Lab to complete its constellation by the end of the decade.

SpaceX launches AST SpaceMobile's BlueBird satellites and Starfall capsule

On 17 June 2026, SpaceX has launched the BlueBird 8, 9 and 10 satellites for AST SpaceMobile aboard a Falcon 9 rocket from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station. The satellites, designed to support AST SpaceMobile's direct-to-smartphone broadband network, are intended to deliver peak data speeds of nearly 200 Mbps, almost double the 98.9 Mbps achieved by the company's earlier Block 1 BlueBird satellites. Their antenna arrays, measuring approximately 2,400 square feet, are the largest commercial communications arrays deployed in LEO to date. A few days later, **on 23 June 2026, SpaceX also launched the Starfall demo mission, a reusable re-entry vehicle, aboard a Falcon 9 rocket from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station.** The mission demonstrated controlled flight of the capsule before splashing down in the Pacific Ocean, intended to support future microgravity research and in-space manufacturing. FAA documentation states that Starfall is designed to carry payloads of up to 2,200 pounds for future cargo transport, but it is not planned for human spaceflight.

MDA Space secures three satellite contracts for defence and Earth observation



Credit: MDA Space

Canada's MDA Space has been selected by British BAE Systems as a subcontractor for the US Space Systems Command's MEO Epoch 2 constellation on 2 June 2026. A component of the US multi-orbit missile defence architecture, the Epoch 2 programme focuses on tracking advanced ballistic and hypersonic threats. MDA Space will design and manufacture antennas and antenna control electronics for the Resilient Missile Warning & Tracking (RMWT) satellites under BAE Systems, which was awarded a $1.2B prime contract from US Space Force Space Systems Command in June 2025.

Later in the month, the Canadian Space Agency also awarded MDA Space a contract worth CA$688M (approx. €425M) to build a replacement satellite for the Radarsat Constellation Mission (RCM), part of the Radarsat+ programme announced in 2023. Furthermore, **on 25 June 2026, Mitsubishi Electric Corporation selected MDA Space to design and manufacture the digital payload, antennas, and key subsystems for Japan's next-generation defence communications satellite**.

IN OTHER NEWS

PLD Space extends investment in CSG launch complex

PLD Space has invested €35M in the development and deployment of its launch complex at the Guiana Space Centre (CSG) in Kourou during the 2025–2026 period. The investment makes PLD Space the first private operator to deploy capital expenditure at the ELM-Diamant site.

Axiom Space establishes Swiss subsidiary

Axiom Space has established Axiom Space Switzerland, a wholly owned subsidiary based in Lucerne, on 2 June 2026. The new entity will support the company's engagement with ESA, ESA Member States, and European research and industrial organisations.

KSAT leads Poseidon EO mission

The Norwegian-based company KSAT has been selected to lead the Poseidon EO mission, a three-year project funded with €5M from the European Commission. The mission aims to improve the detection of oil spills and maritime pollution by using optical and radar satellite data.

Vast expands microgravity research network

Vast has extended its microgravity research and manufacturing network in LEO by signing MoUs with UC San Diego's Sanford Stem Cell Institute, Auxilium Biotechnologies, LambdaVision, and BioOrbi.

Northrop Grumman partners with Apex for Golden Dome

Northrop Grumman and Apex have partnered to develop space-based interceptor satellites for the Golden Dome missile defence programme, with Apex providing its satellite platform while Northrop Grumman contributing to the interceptor payload.

Satellogic partners with SynMax on AI intelligence services

Satellogic has partnered with SynMax to develop AI-powered intelligence products based on its Merlin satellite constellation. The partnership combines satellite imagery with additional intelligence sources for defence and intelligence applications.

SpaceX raises $75B in record Nasdaq IPO, debuting at $2 trillion valuation[1]

SpaceX has reported raising approximately **$75B as a consequence of its IPO at $135 per share**, ahead of the stock being traded on Nasdaq under the ticker SPCX from 12 June 2026. SpaceX's IPO marks the largest IPO on record, placing the company's market capitalisation at approximately $2 trillion. During the IPO, shares opened 11% above the offering price at $150, climbing to $164 during the session before reaching an all-time high of $225 on 16 June. The stock subsequently retraced, briefly dipping below the IPO price of $135 to a low of $147,11 on 23 June before recovering to close the month of June at approximately $170. The IPO follows **SpaceX's S-1 filing** on 20 May, which disclosed 2025 full-year revenue of $18.7 billion and adjusted EBITDA of $6.6 billion, with $4.7B in revenue recorded in Q1 2026.

Isar Aerospace closes €270M Series D to extend Spectrum commercialisation



Credit: Isar Aerospace

German launch company Isar Aerospace has closed a **€270M Series D round** with new investors Island Green Capital and Molten Ventures, alongside existing backers HV Capital, Lakestar, UVC Partners, and KfW Capital, among others. With the new injection, the company aims to manufacture up to 40 "Spectrum" launch vehicles per year. Alongside the industrial scaling, Isar Aerospace plans to use the funding to pursue the expansion of its multinational launch network. Following its dedicated launch pad at Andøya Space in Norway, the company has signed a Letter of Intent with Maritime Launch Services to add Spaceport Nova Scotia as a second site, with additional locations under negotiation.

Rocket Lab acquires Iridium in $8B deal to create vertically integrated operator

Rocket Lab has signed a definitive agreement to acquire Iridium Communications in a **cash-and-stock transaction implying an enterprise value of approximately $8B, announced on 29 June 2026**. Iridium stockholders will receive $54 per share in combined cash and stock, with Rocket Lab securing a $3.6B bridge financing facility from Deutsche Bank and Wells Fargo to fund the cash component. The deal, expected to close in mid-2027 subject to stockholder and regulatory approval, brings together Rocket Lab's launch and spacecraft manufacturing capabilities with Iridium's 66-satellite LEO constellation, globally coordinated L-band spectrum, 2.55 million active subscribers, and a 500-company partner ecosystem. The combined entity would be vertically integrated across the full space value chain, with Rocket Lab's Neutron rocket positioned as the primary vehicle for deploying and replenishing Iridium's next-generation constellation. The acquisition is latest in a sequence of multiple others, including Mynaric and Geost, enabling further business model diversification.

ICEYE and Rheinmetall form space-based joint venture for the European market

On 10 June 2026, on the sidelines of the Berlin Air Show, ICEYE and Rheinmetall have established **Rheinmetall ICEYE Space Solutions GmbH**. The joint venture will provide end-to-end space-based Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR) capabilities for the European market. The venture follows **the award of a €1.7B contract** by the German Ministry of Defence in December 2025 for the two companies to develop and operate a SAR satellite constellation. The initiative also includes four German space startups as initial partners: Reflex Aerospace, OroraTech, constellR and LiveEO.

[1] For further insights: European Space Policy Institute. Why SpaceX's IPO signals a second chance for Europe's digital ambition. ESPI, 2026 (Link)

ICEYE closes €450M series F to expand SAR satellite systems

The Finnish company secured its €450 million Series F funding in a round led by General Atlantic. The round also saw participation from multiple domestic investors including Solidium, Tesi, Varma, Ilmarinen, Lifeline Ventures and Nokia. Qatar Investment Authority and TCV also participated in the round. Announced on 9 June, the new funding enables the company to reach additional government customers, following multiple successful government contract conclusions over the last year.

Global investment firm EQT to acquire German launch services company Exolaunch

Global investment firm EQT has entered into a **definitive agreement to acquire German mission management company Exolaunch** through its EQT X fund, with the transaction expected to close in Q4 2026, subject to customary regulatory approvals. The acquisition will support Exolaunch's expansion into additional services across the satellite mission lifecycle, development of new deployment technologies and scaling of its dedicated and rideshare launch offerings. Exolaunch expects 2026 revenue to increase by approximately 250% compared to 2025 and its workforce by a further 30%, with over 400 satellites booked for launch in 2026. **After being selected last May** by the European Commission as the preferred investment adviser and fund manager for the Scaleup Europe Fund, this investment marks EQT's first operation in the space sector, coming after the **French government's block** of the investment firm's planned €550M acquisition of Eutelsat's passive ground segment infrastructure in January 2026.

EXOLAUNCH

Credit: Exolaunch

Impulse Space raises $500M in Series D to scale in-space mobility infrastructure

US in-space mobility company Impulse Space has raised **$500 million in a Series D round** co-led by 137 Ventures and BANNER VC, with participation from Founder's Fund, Lux Capital and Linse Capital, bringing total capital raised to over $1B. The investment will enable manufacturing capacity expansion and accelerate the development of "Helios", a high-energy kick stage designed to deliver payloads from LEO to higher orbits, scheduled for its first flight in 2027. Impulse Space currently operates "Mira", a flight-proven precision manoeuvring spacecraft, and holds a growing demand for commercial, civil, and government contracts for post-launch orbital delivery services.

MDA Space agrees to acquire Blue Canyon Technologies for $620M

Canada's MDA Space has signed a definitive agreement to acquire US Blue Canyon Technologies (BCT) from RTX's Raytheon business **in an all-cash transaction valued at CA$874 million** (approx. €540 million), financed through senior secured debt. The operation is expected to be closed by the end of 2026, subject to regulatory approvals. BCT is a spacecraft and satellite component manufacturer and mission services provider for commercial, civil, and defence applications. The acquisition adds CA$4.9B (approx. €3B) to MDA Space's opportunity pipeline, expands the company's manufacturing footprint into the US defence space market.

Axiom Space closes $175 million extension to bring total financing to $525 million

US Commercial space station developer Axiom Space has closed **a $175 million extension** to its **previously announced $350 million financing round** led by Type One Ventures and the Qatar Investment Authority, with MUFG Bank joining as a new investor. The financing will be directed towards the continued development of Axiom Station, the planned commercial successor to the ISS.

IN OTHER NEWS

ElevationSpace raises $40M for Space transportation

Japanese re-entry and recovery company ElevationSpace has raised $40 million in a Series B round from SPARX Asset Management and Beyond Next Ventures, among other investors. The fresh capital will be allocated to accelerating development of its re-entry vehicle “Aoba” successor, alongside full-scale commercial entry into European and US markets.

Business Finland approves €28M R&D grant for ICEYE

Finnish SAR satellite company ICEYE has received a €28M continuation grant from Business Finland to support its ongoing research and development programme, focused on advancing next-generation SAR satellite technologies and expanding the company's constellation capabilities.

Dawn Aerospace secures $25M for in-orbit transportation

New Zealand company Dawn Aerospace has secured $25M in funding to expand its efforts in developing both in-space transportation and suborbital spaceplanes. This investment will help the company scale up its work in these areas.

NewOrbit closes $18.5M round for satellite infrastructure

UK spacecraft developer NewOrbit has closed an $18.5M Series A round led by Voyager Ventures, with participation from Atlantic.vc, Lifeline Ventures, LGF, Illusian and angel investors. The round will fund the NEO Production Complex, a dedicated VLEO satellite manufacturing facility opening in 2027.

Katalyst Space raises $12M for GEO servicing demo mission

US satellite servicing startup Katalyst Space Technologies has raised $12M to fund a demonstration mission in geosynchronous orbit. This mission aims to boost the orbit of a NASA observatory and is approaching its launch.

Ubotica raises $11M to scale maritime-intelligence platform

Irish startup Ubotica Technologies has raised $11M to grow the commercial sales of its maritime-intelligence platform called Live Maritime. The company will use the capital to expand its platform's reach and capabilities.

BRUSSELS CORNER



The proposed European Space Act has entered the next phase. The draft report by rapporteur Elena Donazzan (ECR, IT) was published on 3 March, providing the first clear signals of parliamentary positioning. In the Council, significant blocking points remain, notably regarding the authorisation system and governance, echoed also in the recent COMPET Council meeting on 29 May 2026.

In other regulatory developments:

- Despite earlier discussions, space does not feature meaningfully in the Commission's proposal for an **Industrial Accelerator Act** (4 March). This points to an outstanding challenge: How do we overcome siloing between horizontal industrial policy and sector-specific priorities?
- In May, the European Commission adopted a **proposed regulation on the use of the 2 GHz mobile-satellite service (MSS) spectrum** beyond 2027. The proposal reserves one third of the band for governmental and strategic programmes, including IRIS². The remaining spectrum would support commercial satellite services, with half of the commercial allocation reserved for European operators.

Negotiations on the space component of the **European Competitiveness Fund (ECF)** continued in Parliament and Council. While, compared to defence, the space pillar of ECF appears well-developed, with detailed objectives and activities, broader questions persist regarding the overall scope and structure of the ECF instrument. In May, Renew Europe MEPs tabled an amendment to the ECF proposal introducing a new **"Space Exploration" article**. If adopted, it would provide the European Commission with its first explicit mandate to support space exploration activities and the broader ecosystem surrounding them.

In April, the Commission published a **proposal for a Regulation on the European Union Space Services Agency (EUSSA)**, evolving the current mandate EUSPA (EU Agency for the Space Programme). Among the notable changes proposed are:

- a broadening of the Agency's role, also in relation to IRIS²
- introduction of a fee-based revenue component in the Agency's budget
- enhanced oversight of critical space infrastructure
- stronger function in structuring the space data economy

Speaking at the annual European Space Forum in Brussels on 30 June, European Commissioner for Tech Sovereignty Henna Virkkunen announced that the European Commission aims to launch a **call for expressions of interest in September to establish a European industry consortium for sovereign direct-to-device (D2D) satellite capabilities**. The consortium would be integrated with IRIS² and would form part of the Commission's broader strategy to strengthen Europe's technological sovereignty and security.

LOOK AHEAD!



Credit: EU Ireland Presidency

IRELAND TO TAKE OVER EU PRESIDENCY

On 1 July 2026, Ireland will take over the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU for six months. During its term, it will chair Council negotiations on the **EU Space Act**, and on the proposed regulation establishing a permanent legal basis for the **EU Space Services Agency** (EUSPA). The space component of the next **Multiannual Financial Framework** will also sit on its agenda.


Credit: Grand Palais

FRANCE TO HOST THE INTERNATIONAL SPACE SUMMIT

France will host the International Space Summit at the Grand Palais in Paris on **9 and 10 September 2026**. Hosted by the President of the Republic, it will revolve around four themes: science and exploration; the regulation and sustainability of space activities; competitiveness; and security and defence. **Thomas Pesquet** and **Hélène Huby** will serve as Special Envoys, with **General Philippe Adam** as Secretary General.


Credit: Rocket Factory Augsburg

EUROPEAN LAUNCHERS TO PRESS AHEAD

A busy quarter is approaching for Europe's launch sector. **Rocket Factory Augsburg aims to fly its RFA ONE** vehicle for the first time from SaxaVord Spaceport in Scotland over the summer, while **Isar Aerospace returns to Andøya in Norway for the qualification flight** of its Spectrum rocket, after its June attempt was scrubbed. **Arianespace is also set to launch a Meteosat Third Generation weather satellite for EUMETSAT on the next Ariane 6 around late August**, for its 8th flight of the year.


Credit: Exposición Hispania Nostra

SPACE DEBATE EUROPE – NEW EVENT IN MADRID

ESPI, AEE, ESA and Eurisy are joining forces to organise the inaugural edition of **Space Debate Europe** (SDE) in Madrid on 22-23 September. The event will build on synergies with the Plenary Session of the European Interparliamentary Space Conference and will provide for a new platform that goes beyond the traditional boundaries of space, bringing new perspectives and audiences to the table.

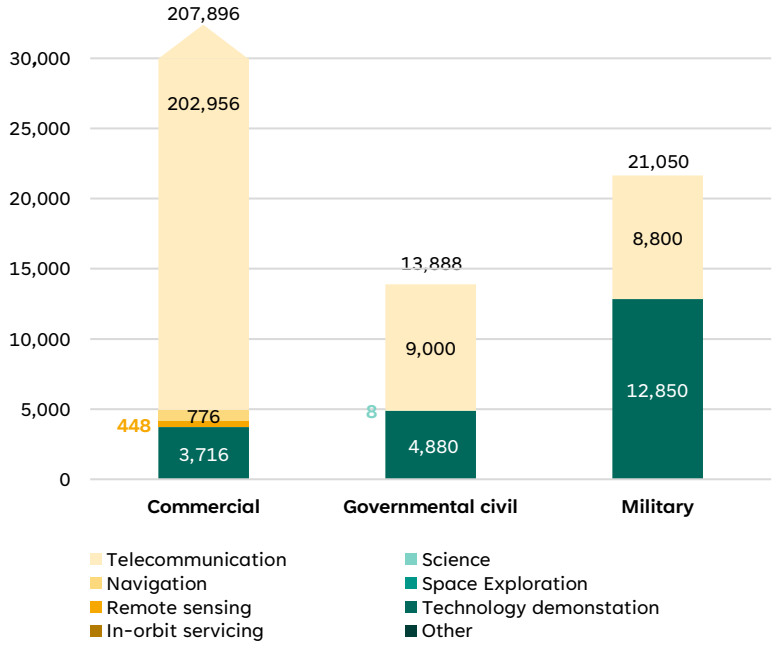
LAUNCHERS & PAYLOADS – JUNE 2026

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	Others (NZ)	Total
Number of launches	14	10	1	0	0	1	3	**29**
Number of spacecraft launched	268	68	36	0	0	7	3	**382**
Mass launched (in kg)	182,100	36,662	20,556	0	0	3166	950	**243,433**

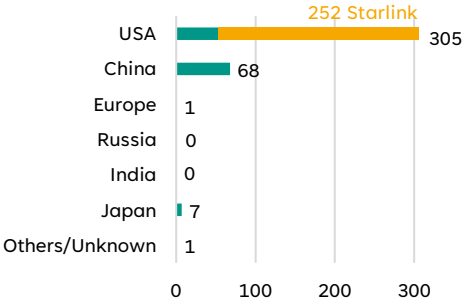
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (14)
2. CASC (7)
3. Rocket Lab (3)

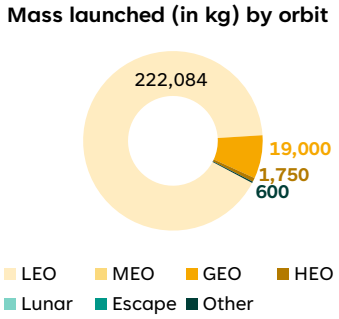
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

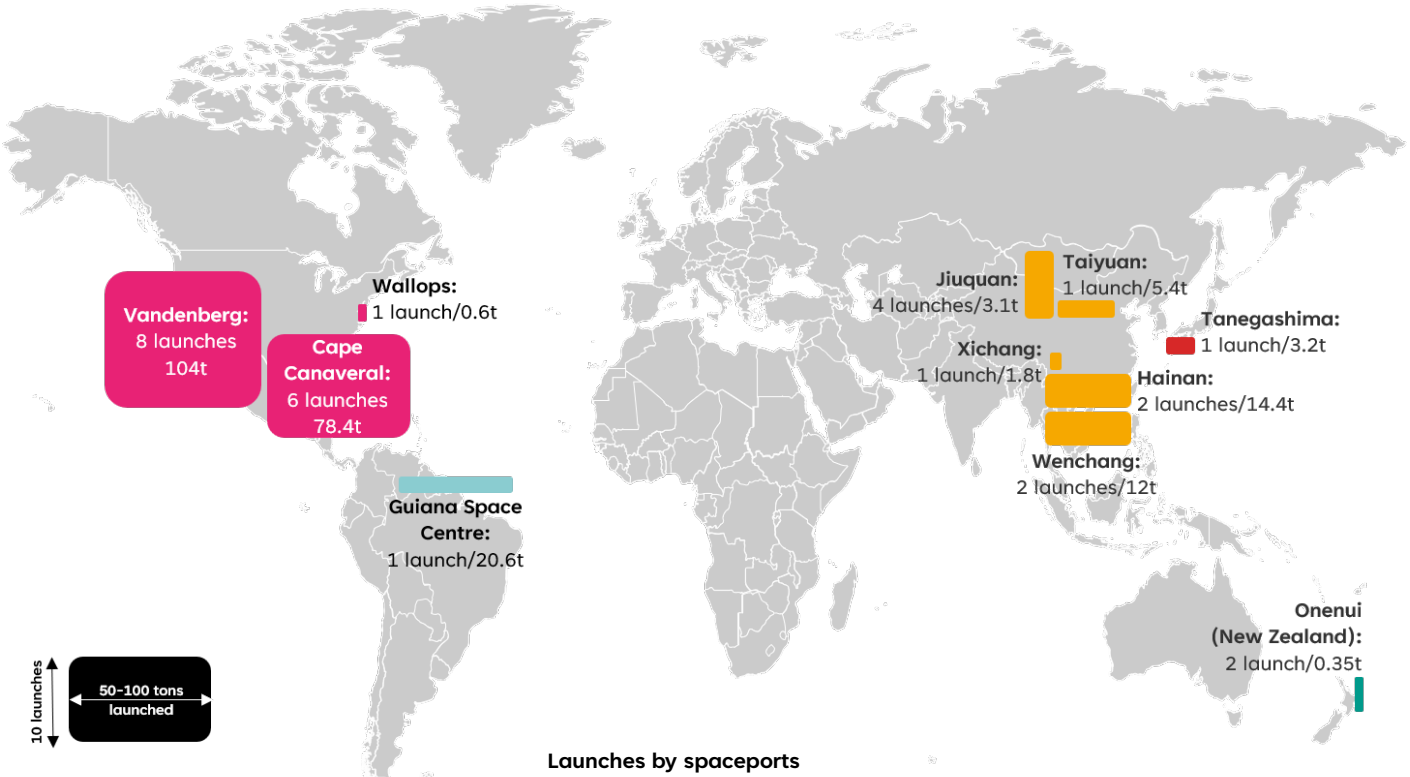


Number of spacecraft launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





Launches by spaceports

*The data is an estimation from ESPI's internal launches dataset, publicly accessible through the **ESPI Launch Dashboard**.*

ESPI Insights

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